

the hymn, *tamasoma jyotirgamaya*, from darkness to light, let us think through how we can build that new political future.

From scarcity to abundance: We must get the engines of the economy to work at full throttle. For this to happen, political parties must ensure that government steps back from market intervention and focuses instead on facilitating competition and entrepreneurship. Tax revenues must be used to lay the foundations that will enable all of our people to harness their potential. This means building the hard infrastructure of cities, highways and schools, and also establishing the soft infrastructure of incentives and regulations. We must find creative ways to ensure that the poorest are provided with opportunities to transform their lives, to

tion marketplace that unleashes our potential and empowers every one of us to do well. Then we will create companies and organisations that address people's needs in an affordable manner. Education must be empowering enough to help us get rid of traditional barriers of caste, religion and gender. Then we will respond to a politics that sets us free, to soar without bounds, rather than one that poisons minds and hearts by dwelling on differences.

From corruption to transparency: We must find ways to reward those in public service suitably and equitably. The politics of the future has to ensure transparent electoral funding, thus tackling corruption at its very root. Institutions should come forward with competitions to identify clean and passionate youngsters—especially from non-political backgrounds—and support them while they work in politics full time. Accountability must be the hallmark of elected officials and the unelected bureaucracy. We will then move from a vicious cycle of bribe-taking and finger-pointing to a virtuous cycle of celebrating dedicated and proactive problem-solving.

From division to unity: We must create an India where all our citizens celebrate their roots and diversity, their languages, cultures,

According to a World Bank estimate, India will become the fourth largest economy in the world by 2020.

160-170

million people will be added to the country's labour force through an increase of 2 per cent per annum by 2020.



'VARYING DEGREES OF PAIN'
Acrylic on canvas by MANIL GUPTA

PUBLIC SERVICES MUST WORK SO PAINLESSLY AND SEAMLESSLY THAT WE DO NOT EVEN NOTICE THAT GOVERNMENT EXISTS.

learn well and to live healthily. Public services must work so painlessly and seamlessly that we not even notice that government exists.

From apathy to participation: We Indians are adept at free riding, at armchair criticism. But we have the institutions, thanks to Panchayati Raj, to enable people at every level to participate in governance. We must see that good people who care about their neighbours and neighbourhoods engaging with the system, contributing their ideas, time and energy. They must plunge into political fray and thus ensure that their efforts have electoral legitimacy, earned through inspiration and perspiration. Indian politics must provide ample room for those educated in public policy and also enable those successful in other arenas to devote time to public causes.

From dependence to empowerment: We must move away from looking at the government to provide us *roti, kapda aur makaan*. We must create a transformed and inclusive educa-

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From soft state to superpower: Our intellectual achievements as a global knowledge hub, our willingness to reach out and help others, our moral standing as a nation that exemplifies fairness, our vibrant economy, our diaspora, and our world-class security forces. Together these will ensure that, on the international stage, India champions justice and compassion from a foundation of multi-dimensional strength. We will lead nations towards cooperation and inclusion. We will help the world heal, and the earth heal.

That is the future of our politics. ■



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